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Lamentations

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Lamentations

A. Overview and Summary.

1. Lamentations is a short book of only five chapters consisting of poems. It is believed to have been written by the prophet Jeremiah about 586 to 575 BC, shortly after the fall of Jerusalem. Jeremiah was a witness to these events, so the tradition that he wrote the book seems valid. Jerusalem was destroyed and the temple of Solomon burned due to the idolatry of the Jewish people; the book was written expressing sorrow and mourning.
2. Lamentation is not unique to this book. Similar expressions of mourning are found elsewhere in Scripture, such as in the Psalms. But this was the most horrific instance of trouble for the Jews to this date, after the destruction of the nation of Israel by the Assyrians about 150 years earlier. God had promised that out of the Jewish nation would arise the Messiah of the House of David who would rule over the world. That hope now seemed dashed. Lamentation is a means to express sorrow and confusion to God which is what we see here.

B. Chapter 1 presents Jerusalem metaphorically as a widow in mourning: “How lonely sits the city that was full of people! How like a widow has she become, she who was great among the nations! She who was a princess among the provinces has become a slave” (Vs. 1:1).

C. Chapter 2 continues the description of the destruction of the city, but there is a realization that it is of the Lord’s hand due to their sin, as He promised: “The LORD has done what he purposed; He has carried out his word, which He commanded long ago; He has thrown down without pity; He has made the enemy rejoice over you and exalted the might of your foes” (Vs. 2:17).

D. Chapter 3 continues with lamentation, but in the middle of all of it, is a cry of hope: “The steadfast love of the LORD never ceases; His mercies never come to an end; they are new every morning; great is your faithfulness. ‘The LORD is my portion, says my soul, therefore I will hope in Him.’ The LORD is good to those who wait for Him, to the soul who seeks Him. It is good that one should wait quietly for the salvation of the LORD” (VS. 3:22-26).

E. Chapter 4 recognizes that Jerusalem's destruction is of the wrath of the Lord, but at the end is a promise of hope: "The punishment of your iniquity, O daughter of Zion, is accomplished; He will keep you in exile no longer" (Vs. 4:22a). But that promise will have to wait until 70 years of exile are accomplished as prophesied by Jeremiah (Jeremiah 29:10-14).

F. Chapter 5 ends with tension expressed by the poet recognizing that the Lord reigns, but crying out with a sense of utter rejection: "But you, O LORD, reign forever; your throne endures to all generations. Why do you forget us forever, why do you forsake us for so many days? Restore us to yourself, O LORD, that we may be restored! Renew our days as of old— unless you have utterly rejected us, and you remain exceedingly angry with us" (Vs.5:19-22).

G. Discussion Questions, Application and Passing it on.

1. Lamentations was written after the destruction of Jerusalem, but it is God's Word and is applicable to His people today. Have you ever felt abandoned by God? Have you cried out to Him with lamentation?
2. Even in the depth of despair as expressed by this book, there is hope for restoration and a return from exile. In your despair, do you sense that God's promises to His people for the future will be fulfilled?

This Old Testament survey was provided by Joshua Nations (JoshuaNations.org)